EFSP Auxiliary ESL Curriculum

Corporate Strategy English

Participant workbook: strategic diagnosis, choices, market analysis, portfolio strategy, growth, M&A, uncertainty, governance, and executive dialogue practice

Audience: advanced ESL learners working in corporate strategy, business strategy, corporate development, transformation, strategic finance, internal consulting, product strategy, commercial strategy, and related roles

Focus: high-level professional English for corporate strategy workplaces, including strategic diagnosis, where-to-play and how-to-win choices, tradeoffs, industry structure, competitive advantage, portfolio strategy, resource allocation, growth strategy, M&A logic, uncertainty, scenarios, operating model, OKRs, executive narratives, and board-level dialogue.

Designed for advanced ESL learners who work in corporate strategy, business strategy, CEO office, transformation, corporate development, strategic finance, internal consulting, product strategy, commercial strategy, or strategy-adjacent leadership roles.

Teaching stance: corporate strategy English is the language of consequential choice. Learners need to frame ambiguous problems, make tradeoffs explicit, connect analysis to decisions, challenge attractive but incoherent ideas, and communicate uncertainty without sounding weak. This course teaches professional communication and judgment, not a single best strategy framework.

How to Use This Workbook

This workbook helps you sound precise and credible in corporate strategy conversations. The goal is not to use more frameworks. The goal is to connect ambiguity to choices, choices to evidence, evidence to resource allocation, and resource allocation to execution.

Your starting point

- Which strategy conversations are hardest for you: problem framing, market analysis, portfolio review, M&A challenge, executive pushback, scenario planning, board prep, or KPI governance?
- Which strategy terms do you understand when reading but avoid when speaking?
- When senior leaders ask for everything, do you become too agreeable, too analytical, too indirect, or too blunt?
- What is one recent strategy meeting you wish you had handled more clearly?

Use the guided dialogue activities below. Every item has four choices and a rationale in the answer key; no open-ended writing is required.

Corporate Strategy Workstream Language

Area	Useful verbs	Example sentence
Framing	diagnose, clarify, structure, hypothesize, prioritize	We should align on the decision question before building the model.
Choices	choose, focus, trade off, sequence, deprioritize	The strategy is not clear until the tradeoff is visible.
Markets	assess, segment, benchmark, map, pressure-test	The market is growing, but value capture may be structurally weak.
Portfolio	allocate, reallocate, fund, harvest, divest	Equal funding would preserve inertia rather than shift resources to the strongest thesis.
Growth	enter, build, buy, partner, integrate	The route to market depends on speed, control, capability gap, and risk.
Execution	govern, measure, escalate, sequence, operationalize	The dashboard should show movement in value drivers, not only initiative status.

Practice Pages

Module 1. Strategy Role, Problem Framing, and Executive Diagnosis

Corporate strategy work begins before analysis. Learners must frame the real decision, separate symptoms from causes, identify the executive audience, and define what would change if the analysis is persuasive.

What you should be able to do

- Distinguish problem statement, symptom, root cause, hypothesis, issue tree, decision question, recommendation, and implementation implication.
- Ask executive-level clarification questions without sounding junior or obstructive.
- Write a concise diagnosis that names the strategic tension rather than listing every fact.

Guided dialogue completion

Situation

The CEO asks the strategy team for a strategy, but the request sounds like a list of initiatives.

Speaker	Line
CEO	We need a strategy for next year. Give me the top twenty initiatives.
Strategy lead	We can build the initiative list, but first we need the strategic choice behind it.
ESL learner	If the output is only a project list, we may miss the real decision. Are we trying to defend the core, enter a new segment, improve margins, or shift resources toward higher-growth businesses?
CEO	All of the above.
ESL learner	Then the first decision is prioritization. We should define the few choices that matter most, the tradeoffs they imply, and the ________ that must move.

Choose the missing language

Option	Phrase
A	mitigation
B	approval
C	resources
D	assumption

Module 2. Strategic Choices: Ambition, Where to Play, How to Win, and Tradeoffs

A strategy is not a slogan or a project list. It is a set of choices about where the company will compete, how it will win, what capabilities it needs, and what it will not do.

What you should be able to do

- Use choice language for ambition, where to play, how to win, capabilities, systems, and management priorities.
- Explain tradeoffs without sounding negative or risk-averse.
- Identify whether an initiative supports the strategy or merely sounds attractive.

Guided dialogue completion

Situation

A leadership team is debating whether to prioritize enterprise customers or mid-market customers.

Speaker	Line
CRO	Enterprise logos create credibility. We should focus there.
Product head	Mid-market customers adopt faster and need fewer custom features.
ESL learner	The where-to-play choice affects product roadmap, sales motion, implementation cost, pricing, and support model. Enterprise may increase contract value, but mid-market may improve velocity and margins.
CRO	Can we do both?
ESL learner	Possibly, but not with the same operating model. If we choose both, we need explicit segmentation and different service levels, not one vague ________.

Choose the missing language

Option	Phrase
A	control
B	disclosure
C	evidence
D	strategy

Module 3. Industry Structure, Competitive Dynamics, and Profit Pools

Attractive growth is not always attractive profit. Learners need language for industry structure, Five Forces, profit pools, competitor moves, barriers, substitutes, and shifting value capture.

What you should be able to do

- Discuss market attractiveness using Five Forces, profit-pool logic, growth, margin, cyclicality, regulation, and structural change.
- Explain why a growing market may still be strategically unattractive.
- Distinguish competitor activity from competitive advantage.

Guided dialogue completion

Situation

A team wants to enter a fast-growing market but has not examined industry structure.

Speaker	Line
Business unit GM	The market is growing 18 percent. We should enter quickly.
Analyst	Growth is strong, but supplier power and buyer power are also high.
ESL learner	Market growth is attractive, but the profit pool may be weak. If buyers can switch easily, suppliers control key inputs, and substitutes are improving, growth may not translate into returns.
GM	So you are saying no?
ESL learner	Not necessarily. I am saying entry needs a clear position, a barrier we can build, and economics that survive competitive ________.

Choose the missing language

Option	Phrase
A	pressure
B	risk
C	owner
D	scope

Module 4. Business Models, Unit Economics, Capabilities, and Advantage

Corporate strategy must explain how value is created, captured, defended, and scaled. Learners need to connect customer value, economics, capabilities, activities, and operating model.

What you should be able to do

- Use business-model and financial terms such as revenue model, gross margin, contribution margin, CAC, LTV, ROIC, WACC, DCF, NPV, and payback accurately.
- Explain strategic advantage in terms of activities, capabilities, cost position, differentiation, switching costs, data, distribution, brand, or scale.
- Challenge business cases that assume growth without credible economics or capabilities.

Guided dialogue completion

Situation

A mature business funds the company, but a new opportunity needs investment.

Speaker	Line
Core BU leader	Our unit generates the cash. Cutting our budget will damage the business.
Innovation lead	Without investment, the new platform will miss the window.
ESL learner	The portfolio question is not which team deserves funding. It is what role each business plays. The core must remain healthy, but some resources may need to shift if the new platform is the stronger future value pool.
Core BU leader	That sounds like punishing performance.
ESL learner	I would frame it as funding enterprise value. We should define the minimum investment to protect the core and the incremental investment needed to test the new platform's ________.

Choose the missing language

Option	Phrase
A	disclosure
B	thesis
C	approval
D	control

Module 5. Portfolio Strategy, Capital Allocation, and Resource Reallocation

Corporate strategy often fails because resources do not move. Learners need language for portfolio roles, capital allocation, mature cash businesses, growth bets, divestitures, adjacency, opportunity cost, and management politics.

What you should be able to do

- Use portfolio terminology accurately: core, adjacency, horizon, business unit, capital allocation, resource reallocation, hurdle rate, divestiture, stranded cost, and opportunity cost.
- Discuss investment, hold, harvest, partner, acquire, divest, and exit recommendations.
- Push back when every business unit requests equal growth funding despite different economics and strategic roles.

Guided dialogue completion

Situation

Every business unit requests a similar budget increase despite different performance and market opportunities.

Speaker	Line
CFO	Every BU is asking for 8 percent more. That is not a strategy.
BU leader	We all have growth plans.
ESL learner	Equal increases may feel fair, but they ignore opportunity cost. We should allocate based on market attractiveness, advantage, capital intensity, confidence in execution, and strategic role.
BU leader	My team will see that as a cut.
ESL learner	Then we need transparent decision rules. Some units may get growth capital, some may get productivity targets, and some may need option funding rather than full-scale ________.

Choose the missing language

Option	Phrase
A	investment
B	assumption
C	mitigation
D	approval

Module 6. Growth Strategy, Market Entry, Partnerships, and M&A Logic

Growth strategy requires a clear thesis: where growth will come from, why the company has a right to win, what route to market is credible, and whether to build, buy, partner, or wait.

What you should be able to do

- Use terms such as organic growth, inorganic growth, adjacency, market entry, beachhead, build-buy-partner, joint venture, strategic alliance, acquisition thesis, synergy, integration risk, and cannibalization.
- Explain why a market may be attractive but still not a good fit.
- Challenge unsupported M&A or partnership logic with questions about value creation, integration, control, culture, and downside risk.

Guided dialogue completion

Situation

The company wants to enter an adjacent market but lacks several capabilities.

Speaker	Line
Corporate development	We can acquire a player and accelerate entry.
Operations	Integration could distract the organization for two years.
ESL learner	The route depends on speed, control, capability gap, integration risk, and economics. Build gives control but may be slow. Buy gives access but may overpay. Partner creates optionality but limits control.
CEO	What do you recommend?
ESL learner	Start with a partnership to validate demand and operating requirements, while screening acquisition targets if the thesis proves ________.

Choose the missing language

Option	Phrase
A	attractive
B	scope
C	timeline
D	assumption

Module 7. Uncertainty, Scenarios, Strategic Options, and Risk Posture

A strong strategist does not pretend the future is certain. Learners need language for scenarios, residual uncertainty, trigger indicators, no-regrets moves, options, big bets, shaping, adapting, and reserving the right to play.

What you should be able to do

- Discuss uncertainty without sounding indecisive.
- Create scenario implications that change decisions, not decorative future stories.
- Recommend strategic moves based on uncertainty level, risk appetite, and trigger indicators.

Guided dialogue completion

Situation

A deal team presents synergy estimates that sound optimistic.

Speaker	Line
Deal lead	The acquisition creates 60 million in annual synergies.
CFO	Where exactly do those synergies come from?
ESL learner	We should separate revenue synergies, cost synergies, tax or procurement benefits, and capability synergies. Each needs an owner, timing, one-time cost, and confidence level.
Deal lead	The revenue synergies are strategic.
ESL learner	Strategic is not enough. Which customers, which products, which channel, what attach rate, and what ________ tells us the combined company can capture it?

Choose the missing language

Option	Phrase
A	evidence
B	disclosure
C	risk
D	owner

Module 8. Execution Governance, Operating Model, KPIs, and Board Narrative

Strategy becomes real through operating model, decision rights, resource shifts, milestones, KPIs, governance, and narrative discipline. Learners must convert strategy into accountable execution without turning it into a long project inventory.

What you should be able to do

- Use execution terms such as operating model, governance, decision rights, initiative, roadmap, milestone, dependency, OKR, KPI, leading indicator, lagging indicator, value driver, and board narrative.
- Separate strategic KPIs from activity metrics.
- Build an executive or board storyline that names choices, evidence, risk, resource implications, and decisions needed.

Guided dialogue completion

Situation

A new regulation could change the economics of a business model.

Speaker	Line
General counsel	We do not know how the rule will be finalized.
Strategy director	Then we need scenarios.
ESL learner	Let's build only scenarios that would change our decision. For each one, we need trigger indicators, financial impact, operational implications, and moves that are no-regrets across scenarios.
CEO	What can we do now?
ESL learner	We can reduce exposure in the highest-________ product, invest in compliance capability, and create an option to shift the model if the strict scenario becomes more likely.

Choose the missing language

Option	Phrase
A	risk
B	assumption
C	mitigation
D	approval

Phrase Bank

Problem framing and diagnosis

- What decision will this analysis change?
- The issue is not only growth; it is whether the growth creates attractive returns.
- I would separate the symptom from the strategic cause.
- Before we build the model, we should align on the decision question.

Strategic choices and tradeoffs

- This is a choice, not just a priority statement.
- If we choose this segment, what are we explicitly not serving?
- The strategy becomes clearer when the tradeoff is visible.
- We can do both only if the operating model supports both.

Market and competitive analysis

- Market growth is attractive, but we need to test value capture.
- Which force puts the most pressure on industry profitability?
- The competitor move matters only if it changes economics, access, or customer behavior.
- The profit pool is shifting, but not necessarily toward us.

Portfolio and resource allocation

- Equal funding is not the same as strategic funding.
- What role should this business play in the enterprise portfolio?
- The resource shift should follow market attractiveness, advantage, and strategic fit.
- We should define the minimum investment to protect the core and the option funding for future growth.

Growth, M&A, and partnerships

- Attractive market does not automatically mean right to win.
- Build gives control, buy gives speed, and partner gives optionality.
- The synergy case needs source, timing, owner, cost, and confidence level.
- The acquisition thesis should explain why we are the best owner of the asset.

Uncertainty and executive communication

- The future is uncertain, but the decision does not have to be vague.
- Which trigger indicators would cause us to revisit the plan?
- This is a no-regrets move across the scenarios we tested.
- For the board, I would lead with the decision, recommendation, risk, and resource implication.

Answer Key and Rationale

Check each answer after completing the dialogue. The rationale shows why the correct phrase is the strongest fit for the real workplace situation.

1. CEO Request: 'We Need a Strategy'

Correct answer	Why it fits
C. resources	'resources' is the precise phrase used in this professional response. The other choices do not fit the dialogue's meaning or grammar.

2. Where-to-Play Debate: Enterprise vs Mid-Market

Correct answer	Why it fits
D. strategy	'strategy' is the precise phrase used in this professional response. The other choices do not fit the dialogue's meaning or grammar.

3. Five Forces: Growth Does Not Mean Profit

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. pressure	'pressure' is the precise phrase used in this professional response. The other choices do not fit the dialogue's meaning or grammar.

4. Portfolio Review: Protect the Core or Fund the New Bet

Correct answer	Why it fits
B. thesis	'thesis' is the precise phrase used in this professional response. The other choices do not fit the dialogue's meaning or grammar.

5. Resource Allocation: Everyone Wants Flat Growth

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. investment	'investment' is the precise phrase used in this professional response. The other choices do not fit the dialogue's meaning or grammar.

6. Market Entry: Build, Buy, or Partner

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. attractive	'attractive' is the precise phrase used in this professional response. The other choices do not fit the dialogue's meaning or grammar.

7. M&A Synergy Challenge

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. evidence	'evidence' is the precise phrase used in this professional response. The other choices do not fit the dialogue's meaning or grammar.

8. Scenario Planning: Regulatory Uncertainty

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. risk	'risk' is the precise phrase used in this professional response. The other choices do not fit the dialogue's meaning or grammar.